

copy his style. A friend brought me up short when he remarked that if I copied Brisbane I would never develop a style of my own. Right then I put Brisbane aside, and the success of my writings has justified my decision not to be Arthur Brisbane but to be Napoleon Hill.

Children try to imitate older people, which is understandable. I see many a grown-up child trying to keep up with the Joneses financially, or trying to keep up the social pace that the Smiths set, with disastrous results. Until you are willing to be your own self, at your own level, you cannot know yourself, nor know what *your* mind can accomplish.

Let nobody bribe you away from being yourself. You are going to make money, and as soon as you do, others are going to see you have what it takes. Fine!—but this is the point at which many a man loses himself. Having built himself from within himself, and having thus attracted attention, he yields to a “big opportunity” to stop building his own wealth and peace of mind, and ties himself to another’s business.

I have been told about a man who sits in a plush office in a huge company that supplies essential components in the field of aerospace. He does not work hard, earns a six-figure salary and bonuses besides. He can gratify almost any reasonable desire that can be gratified with money. But he cannot buy back himself; he allowed himself to be bribed away. So he sits gloomily behind his five-hundred-dollar desk and wishes he had not let the big company buy out the small, growing company which once had been his own—and with it buy all the adventure and personal satisfaction he had known.

Back in the days when \$25,000 would buy what \$75,000 buys today—and I was not earning half of \$25,000 a year, but I was absorbed in what I was doing—I worked hard and happily at publishing the *Golden Rule Magazine*. Perhaps because I had been an adviser to Woodrow Wilson I was approached by Ivy Lee, the public relations expert I have mentioned. He wanted me to join his staff and become a ghost-writer for one of his clients—the Rockefeller interests.

For a moment I was tempted. I listened to his terms: \$25,000 a year on a five-year contract, and of course I was to knock *Golden Rule Magazine* in the head.

The moment passed and I was myself again. I replied, “Nothing doing, Mr. Lee.” If the salary had been a million dollars a year, my answer would have been the same.